

The Guardian, August 11, 2005

When Laptops Are A Pain In The Neck

JACK SCHOFIELD WRITES about the horrors of an increasingly wirefree world. What? Yes, the notebook computer has its negatives thanks to the ergonomic disaster that it is or so Schofield and Jeremy Clarkson seem to agree...

Jeremy Clarkson and I seem to have something in common: we've both been laid low partly by our laptops. Physically, if not financially, he's much worse off than me. According to his column in The Sunday Times, he's visiting an osteopath for a slipped disc, whereas I'm just having physiotherapy for a cricked neck. But in a world where Wi-Fi and notebook computers are replacing wired desktops, this is very likely to become an increasingly common problem for computer users over the next few years.

Clarkson got the same instructions as me: sit up straight.

When computing, you should try to keep your ears, shoulders and hips in line, with the top of your computer screen just below the height of your eyes.

"Fine, but I use a laptop and if I get the screen high enough, I can't see any of the keys," wrote Clarkson on the subject.

As a touch-typist, I don't need to see the keys, but any

laptop with a fixed keyboard makes it impossible to get both the screen and keyboard in an ergonomic position at the same time. To do that, you need to plug in either a separate monitor or keyboard.

My problem arose partly because of the perfectly natural tendency to use the fastest machines around, and both my newest computers - an IBM ThinkPad X31 and an Apple iBook - were notebooks. Both have Wi-Fi, too, and if you work at home, you get extra points for staying-home time.

As a result, I've spent too much of the past 18 months slumped over a notebook rather than sitting upright at a desktop. This helped accustom my upper spine to being in a bad position. Then I woke up one morning with a cricked neck, and the pain didn't go away in a couple of hours, it got worse. And worse. Soon, the only way I could raise my right arm was using my left.

As someone who has read more than one book on computer ergonomics, I was surprised to find my physiotherapist so hostile to notebook PCs. With the keyboard at the correct height, I felt my typing position was comfortable, and my posture was not particularly different from the one used when reading books.

However, keen readers can change their posture at frequent intervals, holding the book in a different position. That's much harder to do with a notebook computer, and I haven't been doing it. Nor have I been taking 10-minute breaks every hour, which is something that I tell everyone else to do.

Notebook computer ergonomics are dreadful, and the built-in keyboards have become far worse as notebooks have become thinner. Few, if any, now offer keys with decent amount of travel.

There are solutions. For example, if using a notebook for any length of time, buy a "notebook riser" or ergonomic stand to lift the screen, or a docking station, and plug in a separate keyboard and mouse. Wireless versions are a good idea. As I can testify, the alternatives can be extremely painful.

To read the complete column, go to: <http://snipurl.com/mediawise1>

NY Times, August 16, 2005

From Blog To Stage, A Pundit Examines The Power Of Politics

LEE PAPA, A blogger, shows his face in "The Rude Pundit in the Year of Living Rudely," a one-man show at the New York International Fringe Festival

Who knew that the Internet would turn out to be a new frontier for theater; a stage that lets us choose our exits and entrances while playing any part we please? Everyone with a blog is a solo performer. And all theatrical forms are blogworthy, from diarylike realism to explosive satire.

Political theater thrives on the Web. No censorship, no compromise. Mainstream news media writers and cartoonists get to shake off time and tone constraints. New talent shows up regularly.

The Rude Pundit roared into the blog arena two years ago, and his audience keeps growing. His ferocious column (subtitled "Proudly Lowering the Level of Political Discourse") hurls analysis and abuse at the war in Iraq, religious fundamentalism, America's immigration policies, Congressional scandals and press timidity (rudepundit.blogspot.com).

The author's identity is unknown to most readers. Last week, though, he unmasked himself in a one-man show, "The Rude Pundit in the Year of Living Rudely," part of the New York International Fringe Festival. "He" is Lee Papa, a tall, stocky

young man in his 30's with long hippie-esque blond hair, who is a writer, professor and sometime actor.

Mr. Papa was seated in a chair with his back to us when the stage lights came up. ("Us" being the 40 or so people who lounged on couches



and secondhand chairs at Dixon Place, the hip performance space on the Bowery that looks like a vintage living room.)

Naked, pink-flesh figures were propped up on the wall behind him. They wore the masks of the famous: Ronald Reagan; President Bush and the first lady, Laura Bush; Vice President Dick Cheney; the presidential adviser Karl Rove; and the conservative commentators Rush Limbaugh and Ann Coulter. Some had penises, some didn't. You could hear people asking whose was bigger. Why did Mr. Limbaugh and Mr. Rove have breasts instead? And what about Ms. Coulter? Like the versatile Greek prophet Tiresias, she had been granted breasts and a penis, but she bested him, she had both at once.

Mr. Papa is a tornado of a writer. So it was refreshing when he began the show with memories of his adolescence. We're all under some kind of blight as adolescents. His blight was Ronald Reagan, the man who "hounded my life for eight years." In the Rude Pundit's world, Mr. Reagan was the cruel patriarch who set the world on its downward spiral of greed and aggression.

What followed was a set of free-form riffs, separated by blackouts. If you have qualms, prepare to feel them now. I felt fine most of the time, and so it seemed did the rest of the audience. ... (more)

For complete column, go to <http://snipurl.com/mediawise2>